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THE FIRST EXPERIMENTS

Looking at Physical Links

EXPLORATIONS

The old-era rails that supported the roof of the only older-looking platform at this railway station, about five kilometres from Chennai Central station, had revealed nothing to me. The markings did not make any sense. They seemed gibberish. If the rails had been constructed in 1956, it was probably too late to find any link to the origins of the station that was well over a hundred years old. The other platforms around it were either newer or being rebuilt.

I was standing at India's oldest functional railway station—Royapuram—in Chennai, south India, in 2017. Opened to the public on 28 June 1856, Royapuram station was inaugurated by the then governor of Madras, Lord Harris, as part of the newly formed Madras Railway. The first train of south India, manufactured by Simpson & Co. Ltd., started its journey from Royapuram to Walajah Road with 300 people, three days after the inauguration—on 1 July 1856. The station remained the headquarters of the Madras and Southern Mahratta Railway until 1922, when it was shifted to Chennai Egmore.

I thought I had a chance of finding significant markers or something of historical significance on the platform I was at, closer to the station's main building. This was the one building that was present in the oldest photographs of the station and had witnessed its growth, or rather, its decline. I was fixated on the relics here, including the station's signboard,